

COMMENTARY

Commentary: Expanding the Scope of Creativity Assessment: Integrating Everyday Creativity to Address 21st Century Complexities

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ABSTRACT

The OECD's PISA Creative Thinking (CT) Assessment, introduced as part of the PISA framework in 2022, marks a significant advancement in recognizing creativity as an essential skill for the 21st century. However, as with all new initiatives, a review of the PISA CT 2022 highlights certain limitations that could benefit from refinement in future iterations of the battery to achieve a more comprehensive and ecologically valid understanding of adolescent creative thinking. In this commentary, we argue for an expansion of the PISA CT's focus to include assessment of everyday creativity (EC), which reflects the practical and contextual realities of contemporary life.

1 | Introduction

The OECD's Programme for International Students Assessment's Creative Thinking (PISA CT 2022) assessment marks a significant advancement in recognizing creativity as an essential skill for the 21st century. However, as with all new initiatives, a review of the PISA CT 2022 highlights certain limitations that could benefit from refinement in future iterations of the battery to achieve a more comprehensive and ecologically valid understanding of adolescent creative thinking. In this commentary, we argue for an expansion of how creativity is conceptualized within the PISA CT by including more naturalistic measures of everyday creativity (EC) that reflect the practical and contextual realities of contemporary life, that are familiar to 15-year-old students of the 21st century, and that align adolescent creative potential with present-day educational priorities.

While this commentary primarily presents a conceptual and contextual critique of the PISA CT, we also propose strategies to expand its applicability. Recognizing the practical constraints of large-scale assessments, we propose suggestions that aim to improve ecological validity, cultural equity, and inclusivity in future iterations of the battery. We argue that nurturing creative agency through context-sensitive assessment represents a critical pedagogical imperative. By examining creativity through a socio-cultural lens, which acknowledges the role of social interactions, cultural norms, and environmental contexts (Glăveanu et al. 2020), we seek to explore how contextual factors influence creative expression and development.

Contemporary scholarship increasingly positions creativity as a contextually embedded process rather than a decontextualized cognitive output (Beghetto and Mangion 2023). Through

this outlook, we position creative outcomes along a continuum of personal and social significance (Glăveanu 2010), emphasize well-being outcomes through the recognition of the role of creativity in fostering self-regulatory behavior (Ivcevic et al. 2023), and argue for the importance of developing agentic actions (Karwowski and Beghetto 2019) through problem solving.

2 | Creativity in Everyday Settings

Creativity in daily life is regarded as an important element, essential for enhancing one's everyday experiences with originality and meaning (Richards 2010; Villanova and Pina e Cunha 2021). EC is, to a certain degree, universal—present in all individuals and demonstrated by many (Ivcevic and Mayer 2009; Richards 2010). Characterized by routine problem-solving, EC can be an outlet where creative potential can thrive and where creative behavior can be stimulated. EC is vital for addressing complex, real-world challenges. EC involves risk taking and improvising while addressing commonplace challenges, such as a child confronting imaginary monsters (Richards 2007), or solving workplace conflicts and dealing with daily challenges (Richards and Goslin-Jones 2018).

In educational settings, children are often observed engaging in self-constructed problem-solving activities involving cycles of creative processes, from problem construction to solution finding and evaluation. This gives rise to the nurturing of a sense of creative confidence (Karwowski and Beghetto 2019), which represents the belief that one can solve problems creatively. Mangion and Riebel (2023) found that young learners engaged in creative behaviors in everyday contexts—from participating in classroom activities to waiting for school transport. In line with traditional definitions of creativity, the learners also recognized creativity as unique, different from the norm or special. Taking inspiration from the 7Cs of Creativity (Lubart 2017), educational settings and daily situations are thought to have the potential to provide environments where creativity can emerge through the dynamic interplay between creators, their consumers, the context within which they work, and the creations they produce, possibly while being incorporated within the curriculum.

Although the current PISA CT assessment includes various problem-solving tasks, these often represent hypothetical scenarios that do not necessarily resonate with students' lived experiences and are constrained by test conditions that may inhibit authentic creative expression. Silvia (2018) clearly states that self-report scales, semi-structured interviews, and cognitive tasks do not lend themselves well to capturing EC. Capturing creative action in real-life contexts, such as typical classroom activities, becomes key to understanding how the uniqueness of situated occurrences can stimulate EC, particularly as it is manifested through little-c creativity involving everyday, practical tasks and mini-c creativity manifested through a sense of analysis and problem-solving (Beghetto and Kaufman 2007). This concept also features in the work of Cotter et al. (2019) where reference is made to the ecological study of creativity. In this context, we emphasize the importance of mini-c creativity, which entails personally meaningful, interpretive creative efforts often observed in improvisations or problem reinterpretations (Beghetto and Kaufman 2007). This form of creativity,

while not necessarily socially validated, reflects the cognitive engagement and agentic behavior central to the development of creative potential.

Capturing little-c and mini-c creativity would require assessment modalities beyond written responses. Multimodal formats, such as verbal narration, visual storytelling, or interactive digital scenarios could provide more authentic outlets for diverse students to express their creative potential. These alternatives are especially important for neurodiverse learners who may excel in creative problem-solving yet struggle with text-based tasks (Wiklund et al. 2024).

Acknowledging that creativity does not only happen under test conditions and that it is manifested regularly outside lab conditions, we invite a more situated approach. An education for the 21st century requires students, future citizens and workers in an increasingly complex society to be able to navigate different challenges. The possibility to assess agentic action (Karwowski and Beghetto 2019) as a vehicle that can transform creative potential into creative behavior is considered to be more indicative of student creativity. The PISA CT could provide an understanding of how young people engage with their daily challenges in a creative manner.

When measuring creative activities in which participating students engaged, the PISA CT battery measures the frequency of engagement and not the type of engagement. This factor was also noted by Kagan and Dumas (2025) where they specifically highlight aspects of creative engagement that are directly related to the creative process and that feature in EC.

Moreover, when assessing students' participation in creative activities, the PISA CT battery predominantly measures the frequency of engagement rather than the nature or the quality of that activity. While frequency is indicative of exposure and access to creative experiences (Briguglio et al. 2022), it does not necessarily reflect the depth of cognitive or conative involvement in the creative process. This limitation was also highlighted by Kagan and Dumas (2025), who argue that creative engagement must be understood in terms of the processes and contexts in which creativity unfolds. This line of thought aligns with our proposal to include measures of EC in the PISA CT assessment to reflect spontaneous, personal, and often informal expressions of creativity that occur in routine settings (Richards 2007). By focusing solely on how often students engage in creative tasks, such instruments risk overlooking crucial aspects like creative problem finding, iterative refinement, and creative engagement leading to evaluation. These observations indicate the need to have a measurement framework that distinguishes superficial participation from substantive, process-oriented engagement, acknowledging that frequency does not necessarily equate with meaningful creative development.

3 | Beyond Product-Oriented Creativity

The current PISA CT defines creativity as the outcome of “original and effective solutions” (OECD 2024). While focusing on product over process in operationalisation and assessment, this position does not capture our outlook outlined above. As

Walia (2019) stipulates, psychological and emotional constructs are vital contributors to the creative process. Adding to this argument, Corazza (2017) and Baldacchino (2025) move beyond the traditional outlook on creativity and directly refer to creative efforts as those that facilitate personal and social wellbeing. More recently, Green et al. (2024) explored the definition of creativity by clearly outlining and separating product and process from definitions of creativity. This implies that EC under the guise of little-c or mini-c creativity is related to usefulness, and contrasts with the definition of creativity in the PISA CT where the emphasis is on the generation, evaluation and improvement of ideas leading to original solutions.

In addition to the issues outlined above, we identified three core limitations that do not account for EC in the assessment. Firstly, the battery presents elements related to temporal constraints. As a consequence, students are not necessarily assessed on their creative potential. Looking at this from the perspective where younger generations need to be equipped with the necessary skills to address modern world complexities, the development of creative potential acquires increased relevance. Creative potential can be developed (Shifflett 2020). Given its dynamic nature, it can be nurtured in different settings such as school or the home (Besançon et al. 2013). This notion provides grounds for us to explore how creative potential can be nurtured through EC.

Secondly, the PISA CT presents a bias with reference to the modality of assessment used, which is predominantly reliant on written responses and may therefore be influenced by students' writing abilities. For instance, labeled under the domain of "social problem solving," Item T630Q01: Carpooling refers to a problem aimed at resolving traffic issues. It attributes 23% variance to writing proficiency. This assessment modality not only marginalizes alternative expressions of creativity, but also discriminates against creative students who may not be able to produce clearly articulated responses. This is exemplified through Item DT500Q01: Library Accessibility. While the topic is useful and promotes inclusion, this task may not be ideal to measure ability to engage with creative *thinking* of students who find it hard to express ideas *in writing*. A case in point would be students with dyslexia who are typically highly proficient at problem-solving but experience difficulties in writing (Wiklund et al. 2024). In these instances, the think-out-loud protocol may be employed (Baxter et al. 2015). Providing the opportunity to also understand the process behind the idea, this method allows participants to verbalize their thoughts while undergoing a task. This method can provide rich data about insights, and interactions during the process (Baldacchino et al. 2014). Acknowledging the implications behind the scoring of these responses, trained LLMs could score audio recorded responses based on fixed parameters thus also avoiding potential rater disparities.

Finally, we note severe reductivism in relation to the aggregation of scores. Acknowledging the work by Green et al. (2024) in relation to the need to observe the process, and not only the product of creative outcomes, using process-oriented metrics could be beneficial. Unit T630, which includes the above-mentioned carpooling task, exemplifies these limitations. Classified as an "evaluate and improve ideas" (OECD 2024, 64) item, it may bias the results for students who have never encountered traffic or carpooling in their lives, such as those in developing countries.

With such items, the students' engagement with the creative process—where they need to articulate the problem, collect relevant information about it and subsequently generate ideas—may vary considerably between different individuals. Students who fail to complete in time due to the processing of information may score low due to this shortcoming. Students from other cultures who are subject to different lifestyles and cultural norms may therefore be disadvantaged when taking the PISA CT test. This notion is exemplified in the performance of students from Eastern countries. Despite surpassing the OECD average in mathematics, reading, and science, Hong Kong (China), Macao (China), and Chinese Taipei performed low or below the OECD average in creative thinking (OECD 2024). Muench et al. (2022) found that the Confucian type of learning and creativity practiced in Eastern countries differentiates from styles practiced in Western countries. Their findings suggest that this style of learning does not align well with Western educational systems that prioritize frequent testing and intensive performance monitoring; in fact, it may be negatively impacted, as reflected in lower PISA score. In a cross-cultural study, Loewenstein and Mueller (2016) found that while both Chinese and American participants valued novelty, the former used broader cues than the latter to assess creativity. The above elements and the inappropriateness of the choice of items predominantly designed for the Western hemisphere could be areas that may be further developed in future iterations of the PISA CT.

A potential resolution lies in incorporating culturally neutral, vignette-based tasks that stimulate everyday decision-making or social problem-solving activities relatable across various cultures. For example, instead of a culturally specific "carpooling" task, an instruction could involve organizing a group activity or resolving a shared classroom challenge. These tasks could include both structured and multiple-choice responses as well as open-ended options, thus making coding of responses more streamlined. Moreover, AI-driven responses of quantitative components and textual analysis could support the integration of limited qualitative responses without compromising the assessment framework. In favor of objective and multilingual scoring, among others, the use of LLMs to assess creative thinking was also proposed by Benedek and Beaty (2025). Recent research by Luchini et al. (2025) also explores AI-driven scoring for creativity.

4 | Towards a More Nuanced and Culturally Representative Measure of Creative Thinking

Building on the above, we believe that adopting a socio-cultural perspective on creativity by recognizing its dependence on social interactions, cultural norms, and environmental contexts (Glăveanu et al. 2020) can enhance the PISA CT assessment's relevance. Future iterations of the PISA CT could account for a more situated approach acknowledging contextual events and activities relatable to 15-year-old students of the 21st century. Additionally, the PISA CT could incorporate evaluations from educators regarding students' everyday creative practices, which can yield a more nuanced understanding of how creativity is fostered within diverse societal frameworks. This approach not only broadens the conceptualisation of creativity as a practical cognitive skill but also offers insights into educational

policies aimed at equipping young people with the creative competencies that are essential for thriving in complex societies. Moreover, the PISA CT could also be developed to better reflect cultural inclusion, as the present assessment is heavily skewed towards Western cultures. This is also noted by Álvarez-Huerta et al. (2025) who observe that designing a test that “accurately addresses creative thinking in different cultures” (p. 3) may be difficult, and that the definition of creative thinking itself can be problematic due to the different types of understanding in different cultures. This claim implies that obtaining homogeneity in this respect is a challenge that PISA CT may need to factor in (Barbot and Kaufman 2025). Issues related to cross-cultural perceptions ultimately lead to implications on the estimation methods, that according to Rutkowski and Rutkowski (2025) the OECD has been working on rectifying since 2015.

Our proposition is bold and we acknowledge that it is not easily attainable. A shift in perspective of how PISA CT is to be conceptualized is required. This shift may be partially operationalized through hybrid assessment models, where students' creative performance is measured through both fluency and depth of engagement with a set of culturally fair scenario-based tasks. A suggestion would be to employ rubrics that assess originality, flexibility, elaboration, and problem-construction skills in parallel with process indicators which include iterations and reflections. This could see the enrichment of the data evaluated also making it more possible to prescribe appropriate strategies for improvements which may be more culturally sensitive and inclusive based on the coded responses. Immediate courses of action may include the establishment of measurement criteria that can assess EC. Contextualized items would be designed based on criteria to measure the appropriateness and meaningfulness of the solutions proposed by surveyed students while also looking into observable manifestations of creative confidence (Karwowski and Beghetto 2019). In their work in this Special Issue, Álvarez-Huerta et al. (2025) also note the need for an improvement in the assessment design. They distinguish between assessment of creativity and assessment for creativity, emphasizing the need to assess the latter to be able to design better strategies for the enhancement of creativity. Moreover, Myszkowski and Storme (2025) argue for the decomposition of the PISA CT items into “originality” and “appropriateness” components. As per definition, EC can be found at the intersection of the two constructs (Richards 2010). The proposition by Myszkowski and Storme (2025) further reinforces our point about addressing EC in future iterations of the PISA CT battery.

Assessing EC to make bold generalizations would also benefit from qualitative data that can facilitate an understanding of the creative process undertaken by students. Self-reflections outlining how students engage with creative behavior could offer valuable opportunities for policymakers to enhance commensurate offerings when designing educational outcomes that match the needs created by the challenges of the 21st century, which have been aptly described as Brittle, Anxious, Nonlinear, and Incomprehensible—BANI (Hrynychak and Motuzka 2023). Under fast-changing societal and industrial conditions in the information age, it is imperative that students are not only able to generate original ideas but that they can also engage with perspective taking and possibility thinking through cognitive versatility (Baldacchino 2022).

In recognition of these fast-emerging lifestyles (OECD 2025) assessment frameworks are needed that mirror the real world. Transcending traditional assessments of creativity to embrace sociocultural complexity, PISA CT could facilitate educational systems and their capabilities in fostering creative potential in the workforce and citizens of tomorrow. This shift requires the understanding of creativity as a skill that is practiced in different real-life contexts. With this conceptualization, the interplay between learning and their rapidly evolving contexts could come to the fore.

In parallel with content refinement, we would like to see the PISA CT development process incorporating a broader spectrum of cultural and experiential perspectives. We recommend the establishment of an international item development advisory board that would review tasks for cultural bias, ecological relevance, and item accessibility.

In line with recommendations by Puthillam et al. (2024), assessment frameworks aspiring to achieve global comparability must reflect the lived diversity of the populations they evaluate. A robust item validation protocol across diverse samples would reduce the embedding of cultural assumptions and promote a more equitable understanding of adolescents and their aptitudes for creativity across borders.

5 | Conclusion

In this commentary, we advance the conversation about the PISA CT battery by proposing a practice-oriented recalibration of the test through the integration of EC. We argue that apart from perspectives that focus purely on what is original and appropriate, creativity could be assessed as a situated, agentic process emerging within the lived realities of young people.

To this end, we propose the adoption of hybrid assessment models that move beyond written modalities to include multimodal and process-sensitive approaches, such as culturally neutral, vignette-based tasks and think-aloud protocols. We also suggest augmenting the assessment with educator-informed observations and student self-reflections. We also propose that scoring using rubrics that capture process indicators like iteration instances as well as originality, appropriateness, and elaboration are used alongside traditional methods. AI-assisted scoring, particularly through the use of multilingual LLM-based analysis, could facilitate consistency and scalability while reducing cultural and linguistic biases.

Embedding these revisions, we believe that the PISA CT shall become more ecologically valid, inclusive, and educationally relevant.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analyzed during the current study.

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